

Academic Paper

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From Monument to Feed

Public memory after independence and the algorithmic custodianship of 1971

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Abstract

Bangladesh built the public memory of its 1971 Liberation War in stone, ritual, and textbook: the Shaheed Minar, the National Martyrs' Memorial at Savar, the calendar of national days, the canonical figure of three million martyrs. This essay argues that the custodianship of that memory is migrating from these state-curated "sites of memory" to algorithmic platforms governed by engagement rather than commemoration, and that the migration is arriving in Bangladesh at the precise moment the last eyewitnesses of 1971 are dying, so that the war is passing into cultural memory for the first time through a recommender system rather than through the state and the family. Reading the last decade as a single struggle over mnemonic infrastructure — the Shahbag movement of 2013, the Digital Security Act of 2018, and the rupture of 2024–2025 — it shows how the feed has displaced the monument as the place where the meaning of the nation's founding is now decided, and asks what a memory governed by ranking code, rather than by ceremony, does to a nation's relationship with its own origin.

Introduction

Every nation that is born of violence must decide how to remember the violence that bore it. For Bangladesh the decision was, for half a century, largely the state's to make. The Liberation War of 1971 — the nine months of mass killing, mass rape, and mass displacement that separated East Pakistan from West and produced a sovereign Bengali state — was consecrated in public memory through the instruments a modern state has for such work: the monument, the memorial day, the school textbook, the state broadcast, the official figure. To remember 1971 correctly was, in effect, to remember it the way the Shaheed Minar and the National Martyrs' Memorial instructed one to remember it, on the days the calendar set aside for the purpose.

That arrangement is breaking down, and not for the reasons memory scholars usually give. It is not only that the politics of memory in Bangladesh has always been contested, though it has. It is that the infrastructure on which public memory is carried has changed. Where a Bangladeshi under twenty-five now encounters 1971 is not, in the first instance, the memorial at Savar or a chapter in a Board textbook. It is a Facebook feed, a YouTube recommendation, a TikTok reel, a thread surfaced by a ranking algorithm that has no commemorative intention whatsoever. The

carrier of the nation's founding memory is becoming the platform, and the platform's logic is not the logic of the monument.

This essay argues that the custodianship of 1971 is migrating from what Pierre Nora (1989) called *lieux de mémoire*, the state-authored sites in which a society deposits its memory, to algorithmic feeds governed by the engagement logic of platform capitalism; and that the true significance of this migration is temporal. Bangladesh has reached the moment, described in Jan Assmann's (1995, 2011) theory of cultural memory, when a foundational event passes out of living, communicative memory — the memory carried by those who were there — and into cultural memory, the institutionalised memory of those who were not. Every nation crosses this threshold roughly three generations after its founding trauma. Bangladesh is crossing it now. What makes its crossing unprecedented is that it is the first in history to be mediated by a recommender system. The generation that will inherit 1971 is learning it from the algorithm.

I develop the argument in three movements. The first establishes the theoretical stakes: how the state built 1971 in stone (drawing on Halbwachs, Nora, Connerton, and the scholarship on 1971's public memory), and how memory studies has theorised the shift from a *collective* memory anchored in shared sites to a *connective* memory distributed across networks (Hoskins, van Dijck, Hirsch). The second turns to the platform itself, asking what it means for a recommender system indifferent to reverence and to truth to become a custodian of national memory (Gillespie, Bucher). The third reads the last decade of Bangladeshi history — the Shahbag movement of 2013, the Digital Security Act of 2018, and, more briefly, the rupture of 2024–2025 — as a single, accelerating contest over who controls the nation's mnemonic infrastructure. Throughout, my aim is analytical rather than partisan. The events in question are among the most bitterly disputed in Bangladeshi public life, and the argument here is about the *dynamics* by which memory is now made and unmade, not about which party's version of 1971 deserves to win.

Building the nation in stone: the architecture of state memory

Maurice Halbwachs (1992), founding the sociology of memory, established the proposition on which everything that follows depends: memory is social. Even the most personal recollection is reconstructed within "social frameworks" — the family, the class, the nation — that supply its terms and sustain its persistence. A memory with no community to carry it dies. It followed, for

the states that emerged from the twentieth century's wars, that a nation wishing to endure had to build the frameworks within which its founding could go on being remembered after its witnesses were gone.

Pierre Nora (1989) gave those frameworks their most influential name. Modern societies, he argued, no longer possess *milieux de mémoire*, real environments of living memory carried in habit and speech; they possess instead *lieux de mémoire*, sites of memory — monuments, archives, anniversaries, emblems — deliberately constructed to arrest a memory that would otherwise dissolve under the "acceleration of history." The site of memory is a defence against forgetting, and it is always, at least in part, an act of the state. Paul Connerton (1989) added the bodily dimension: societies remember not only through inscription in stone and text but through *commemorative ceremonies* and habitual practice, the ritual re-enactment by which a community rehearses its own past into the present.

Independent Bangladesh built its *lieux de mémoire* with unusual intensity, because its very existence was a memory claim. The Shaheed Minar, first raised to the martyrs of the 1952 Language Movement and rebuilt many times since, fixed the pre-history of the nation in a single silhouette and bound it to a date, the twenty-first of February, whose dawn procession is one of the most disciplined commemorative ceremonies in South Asia. The National Martyrs' Memorial (Jatiyo Smriti Soudho) at Savar, designed by Syed Mainul Hossain and completed in 1982, gave the war of 1971 its central architectural expression, its seven receding planes ascending to a point that the whole apparatus of the state visits each sixteenth of December. Around these anchor-sites the state arranged a dense calendar — Independence Day on the twenty-sixth of March, Victory Day on the sixteenth of December, Martyred Intellectuals Day on the fourteenth — and a canon carried in the school textbook and the state broadcast: the figure of three million martyrs, the two hundred thousand violated women honoured, and contested, under the state title *birangona*, the narrative of a people's war led by the founding leader.

This canon was never neutral, and the scholarship on 1971's public memory has shown how much labour and how much silence went into its construction. Nayanika Mookherjee's (2015) study of the *birangona* demonstrates how the state's public commemoration of wartime rape simultaneously honoured and re-wounded the women it named, folding their suffering into a national narrative on the state's terms. Yasmin Saikia (2011) recovered the memories — of

Bengali, Bihari, and Pakistani women alike — that the triumphalist national story could not accommodate. Sarmila Bose's (2011) contested revisiting of the casualty figures, however one judges it, marked the point at which the canonical numbers themselves became a public battleground. And the deepest fault line ran through the nation's party politics: the rival custodianships of the Awami League, which anchored the war's memory in the founding leadership of Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, and of the forces around the Bangladesh Nationalist Party, which foregrounded the wartime declaration of independence associated with Ziaur Rahman. For fifty years the memory of 1971 was fought over. But it was fought over *within* a shared infrastructure. The battle was for control of the monument, the textbook, the anniversary, and the airwaves — sites the state owned and could, in principle, govern. Memory was contested; its infrastructure was sovereign.

From collective to connective: how the carrier of memory changed

The sovereignty of that infrastructure rested on a temporal assumption that is now expiring. Jan Assmann (1995, 2011), extending Halbwachs, distinguished two registers of collective memory. *Communicative memory* is the living memory of lived experience, carried in everyday interaction and personal testimony; it is warm, informal, and mortal, and it reaches back only about eighty years — three or four generations — before it fades with the death of those who hold it. *Cultural memory* is what a society institutionalises to outlast that horizon: the fixed texts, rites, monuments, and canonical figures through which an event is carried once no one alive remembers it. The transition from the one to the other is the most delicate passage in the life of a national memory, because it is the moment at which a society decides, more or less deliberately, what the objectified version of its founding will be.

Bangladesh is in that passage now. The combatants, witnesses, and survivors of 1971 are in their seventies and eighties; within a decade or two the war will have no living rememberers at all. In Assmann's terms, 1971 is completing its migration from communicative into cultural memory. Under twentieth-century conditions the state would have managed that migration through the instruments described above, and the outcome would have been some more or less official cultural memory, deposited in stone and syllabus. But the migration is not happening under twentieth-century conditions. It is happening on the platform.

Memory studies has a name for the change of carrier. Andrew Hoskins (2011, 2018) calls it the "connective turn": the passage from a *collective* memory organised around shared, relatively stable objects to a *connective* memory in which remembrance is a property of the network's connections themselves — continuously circulated, updated, remediated, and dissolved. In the connective condition, memory is less a thing that is stored and retrieved than a process that is perpetually re-performed through sharing. José van Dijck (2007), in her study of "mediated memories," had already shown that the technologies through which we record and recall are never neutral vessels; they shape what can be remembered and how. Astrid Erll (2011) describes the mechanism as *remediation*: a memory travels by being carried from one medium into another, and is altered by each carriage. And Marianne Hirsch's (2012) concept of *postmemory* names precisely the position of the generation now inheriting 1971 — those who did not live the event and "remember" it only through the images, stories, and objects transmitted to them, an inheritance so mediated that it can feel like memory yet is entirely second-hand.

Bring these together and the argument sharpens. The generation crossing Assmann's threshold on Bangladesh's behalf is a postmemory generation whose inheritance is delivered by connective, not collective, means — and the medium of that connection is the algorithmic feed. Where the postmemory of earlier national traumas was mediated by the family album, the documentary, and the museum, the postmemory of 1971 is increasingly mediated by whatever a recommender system elevates. The question of what Bangladesh's cultural memory of its founding will be is therefore, to a degree without precedent, a question about what the algorithm surfaces.

There is a further reason the change of carrier matters, and it concerns forgetting as much as remembering. Paul Connerton (2009), revising his earlier work, argued that the conditions of modernity actively produce forgetting: the speed, disposability, and ceaseless replacement of the modern media environment corrode the very capacity to hold a shared past in common. The feed is that tendency built into an architecture. It is made to move on, to replace, to bury yesterday's salience under today's, and its default disposition toward any memory, however sacred, is to scroll past it. A cultural memory entrusted to such a carrier is entrusted to a machine whose native motion is forgetting, interrupted only where a memory happens to generate the engagement that briefly stays its hand.

The algorithm as custodian: engagement logic versus commemorative logic

To say the algorithm has become a custodian of memory is to make a specific claim about a specific kind of power, and platform scholarship allows us to state it precisely. Tarleton Gillespie (2014) argues that algorithms of public relevance do not merely *sort* pre-existing knowledge; they participate in *constituting* it, defining what is "relevant" and thereby shaping what a public takes to be worth knowing and, ultimately, real. Taina Bucher (2018) shows that this power operates through visibility: the feed decides what appears and what does not, and to be consigned to algorithmic invisibility is a distinct kind of erasure, while to be amplified is a distinct kind of consecration. José van Dijck, Thomas Poell, and Martijn de Waal (2018) describe the broader condition as *platformisation*, in which the infrastructures of public life are reorganised around the economic and technical logic of a few dominant platforms. Safiya Noble (2018) demonstrates that the results such systems return are not a neutral mirror of a society's knowledge but an artefact of commercial ranking, capable of entrenching a society's worst assumptions under the alibi of objectivity.

The consequence for national memory is a collision of two logics. The logic of the monument is *commemorative*: it instructs a public to remember a designated event, in a designated way, at a designated time, and its governing values are solemnity, fixity, and reverence. The logic of the feed is *engagement*: it elevates whatever holds attention, and its governing values are salience, novelty, emotional charge, and shareability. These logics do not merely differ; they select for different pasts. The commemorative logic elevates the canonical because it is canonical. The engagement logic elevates the affecting, the provocative, and the controversial because those perform — and a solemn martyr performs less well than an incendiary claim about that martyr. When the feed becomes the dominant carrier of memory, the mnemonic salience of an event is decided no longer by the state's judgement of its dignity but by the platform's measurement of its capacity to provoke a click. Memory passes under the government of a system that is, by design, indifferent to both truth and reverence.

Two features of platform custodianship deepen the problem in a country like Bangladesh. The first is the economy the logic serves. The feed's ranking is not indifferent by accident but by design, because the resource it is built to maximise is attention, the scarce commodity of the platform business; a memory appears in it only insofar as it can be converted into engagement,

and is otherwise passed over. The second is the asymmetry of platform governance between the global North and the global South. The human and technical resources that platforms devote to moderating content, adjudicating context, and curbing coordinated falsehood are concentrated overwhelmingly in a few dominant languages and markets and thin to the point of near-absence in Bengali. The custodian of 1971's memory is therefore not only a system indifferent to reverence and to truth; it is one that governs Bengali public memory with a fraction of the care it gives to English, from a corporate distance at which the specific weight of a *razakar* or a *birangona* does not register at all. Custodianship has passed to an authority that is at once indifferent, commercial, and absentee (van Dijck, Poell, & de Waal, 2018; Noble, 2018).

This is the sense in which the recommender system has become a custodian: not that it curates memory with any intention, but that its indifferent optimisation now performs the selective function that the state once performed deliberately. The three movements that follow trace how Bangladesh discovered this, in sequence, over a single decade.

Shahbag 2013: the first algorithmic memory movement

The first sign that the infrastructure of 1971's memory had changed came in February 2013, and it came from below. On the fifth of that month the International Crimes Tribunal, the domestic court established to try the collaborators of 1971, sentenced Abdul Quader Mollah, a senior figure of the Jamaat-e-Islami convicted of atrocities during the war, to life imprisonment rather than death. Within hours a small group of online activists and bloggers had called a gathering at the Shahbag intersection in Dhaka; within days the gathering had become an occupation of tens of thousands, the Ganajagaran Mancha, demanding capital punishment for the war criminals of 1971 and the completion of a reckoning that many felt the state had left unfinished for four decades (Dhaka Tribune, 2017).

What was new about Shahbag was not its content — the demand to punish 1971's collaborators was as old as the republic — but its infrastructure. It was convened and sustained not by a party, a newspaper, or the state, but by a networked public assembling on Facebook and the Bengali blogosphere. It was, in the vocabulary of Zeynep Tufekci's (2017) study of networked protest, a movement that used the platform's capacity to coordinate a crowd without an organisation, achieving in days a scale that older movements took years to build. In the terms of this essay,

Shahbag was the first *algorithmic memory movement* in Bangladesh: a reactivation of the communicative energy around 1971, at national scale, generated not by the custodial institutions of the state but by the connective circulation of a networked public. The memory of the war, which the state had deposited in monuments and anniversaries, was being taken up and re-performed by citizens on infrastructure the state did not own.

The infrastructure also carried the movement beyond the nation's borders in a way the monument never could. Shahbag was sustained partly on Bengali-language blogging platforms such as Somewhere In Blog and by a Bengali diaspora that amplified it across time zones, so that the reactivated memory of 1971 circulated at once in Dhaka, London, and New York. This is what Astrid Erll (2011) calls travelling memory: a remembrance that exists in its movement across media and territories rather than in a fixed location. The memory of the Liberation War, anchored for four decades to particular sites on Bangladeshi soil, had become portable, and its portability was a property of the platform.

Tufekci's (2017) argument also predicts Shahbag's vulnerability, and here the case becomes darker and more instructive. Networked movements, she shows, can achieve enormous scale quickly precisely because they skip the slow work of building organisational structure — and that same absence leaves them fragile, unable to negotiate or to withstand a determined counter-mobilisation. Shahbag's counter-mobilisation was equally a creature of the new infrastructure. A rival networked public, organised around the religious-political platform Hefazat-e-Islam, reframed the Shahbag activists not as claimants of 1971's justice but as "atheist bloggers" insulting Islam, and circulated lists of named individuals. The consequences were lethal. Ahmed Rajib Haider, a blogger prominent in the Shahbag mobilisation, was murdered on the fifteenth of February 2013, and a succession of bloggers and secular writers would be killed in the years that followed (SAMSN/IFJ, 2016). The same platforms that had allowed a networked public to reactivate the memory of 1971 allowed an opposing networked public to redefine and to hunt the people carrying it. Connective memory, Shahbag revealed, has no single custodian and no built-in reverence; the infrastructure that amplifies commemoration amplifies its enemies with equal efficiency.

Shahbag thus stands as the hinge of this history. It demonstrated that the memory of 1971 had escaped the exclusive custody of the state and entered the connective domain, where it could be

mobilised at a scale and speed the monument could never generate — and where it was, for the same reason, exposed to contestation, distortion, and violence the monument had held at bay. The state's response to that demonstration would define the next phase.

The Digital Security Act: a memory law for the feed

Faced with the loss of its mnemonic monopoly, the Bangladeshi state did what states throughout history have done when they wish to fix an official version of the past: it turned to law. The instrument was the Digital Security Act of 2018, and while the Act was in most respects a general instrument of online repression — condemned as such by Amnesty International (2018) and Human Rights Watch (2018) — one of its provisions is of direct interest here. Section 21 made it a criminal offence for "any person using the digital medium" to make or instigate "any propaganda or campaign against the liberation war of Bangladesh, the spirit of the liberation war, the father of the nation, the national anthem, or the national flag," punishable on a first offence by up to ten years' imprisonment and a fine of up to one crore taka, and on a repeat offence by imprisonment for life (Government of Bangladesh, 2018; Jural Acuity, n.d.).

Read through the lens of memory studies, Section 21 is something more specific than a censorship clause. It is a *memory law*: a statute that criminalises particular representations of the past in order to protect an official version of it. Comparative scholars of such laws — Uladzislau Belavusau and Aleksandra Gliszczynska-Grabias (2017) chief among them — have shown how states across the world have increasingly sought to govern history through legislation, and how memory laws sit in permanent tension with freedom of expression precisely because they place a national narrative beyond the reach of argument. What makes Section 21 a distinctively twenty-first-century memory law is its object. It does not merely defend the monument or the textbook; it reaches onto the feed. It is the state's attempt to re-extend its custodianship of 1971 onto the very connective infrastructure that Shahbag had shown to be beyond its control — to legislate the platform back into obedience.

The attempt reveals the depth of the state's predicament more than the reach of its power. A monument governs memory by its mere presence; it needs no enforcement, because it does not forbid, it simply stands. A memory law governs by threat, and the need to legislate reverence is already a confession that reverence can no longer be assumed. The DSA criminalised what the

monument used to accomplish by consecration alone, and in doing so it converted the state from the serene custodian of 1971 into one more anxious combatant in the contest over it — now armed, and now himself an object of the contest, since a law invoked to protect the memory of the founding leader inevitably bound that memory ever more tightly to the fortunes of the party wielding the law. The Act's chilling effect on journalism and ordinary speech was extensively documented, and when it was eventually repackaged as the Cyber Security Act of 2023, rights groups noted that the substance of its repressive provisions largely survived the change of name (The Diplomat, 2023). The state had tried to answer a change in infrastructure with a change in statute. The infrastructure would have the last word.

2024–2025: the overthrow of the memory monopoly

It had that word in 2024, and although a full account of the July Uprising lies beyond this essay's scope, its bearing on the memory of 1971 is too direct to omit. The movement that ended fifteen years of Awami League government began, in form, as a protest over the quota system in public employment — and the quota at its centre was a memory institution. The reservation of thirty per cent of government posts for the descendants of freedom fighters made the inheritance of 1971 into a literal, distributable material asset, so that the question of who could claim the mantle of the Liberation War was also, concretely, the question of who got a government job. When a High Court judgment reinstated that quota in June 2024, the argument that erupted was, beneath its administrative surface, an argument about the ownership of the war's meaning by a generation with no memory of the war at all (International Crisis Group, 2024).

The decisive moment was mnemonic and it was viral. After the Prime Minister appeared to suggest that those opposing the freedom-fighter quota were aligned with the *razakars* — the collaborators of 1971, the most stigmatised figure in the national lexicon — protesting students turned the slur into a chant: *Tumi ke, ami ke — Razakar, Razakar* ("Who are you, who am I — Razakar, Razakar"). The most sacred negative signifier of Bangladeshi public memory, the very name the state had spent fifty years teaching citizens to abhor, was seized and worn ironically by the postmemory generation, and it spread across the feed with a velocity no monument could match or answer (The Daily Star, 2024). Whatever one makes of the act, its mechanism is the argument of this essay in miniature: a foundational memory-symbol was reappropriated and redefined not through any institution of the state but through the reappropriative, ironic,

accelerative logic of the platform. The state's response confirmed the diagnosis from the opposite direction. It switched the infrastructure off, imposing a near-total internet blackout across the country for days in mid-July 2024 (Access Now, 2024) — an implicit admission that the feed had become the decisive arena of the contest, and that the only way to win the argument over memory was to unplug the medium carrying it.

What followed the government's fall in August 2024 was the rewriting of public memory in real time, and on camera. Murals and statues of the founding leader were defaced and pulled down; in February 2025, after the deposed Prime Minister addressed her supporters in a live online broadcast, crowds razed the house at Dhanmondi 32 where Sheikh Mujibur Rahman had lived and been killed, the very building that had been the country's central relic of the founding (The Business Standard, 2025). Within the year the central bank issued new banknotes that removed Mujib's portrait, the most widely circulated image in the country, and replaced it with, among other motifs, graffiti from the July Uprising itself (The Daily Star, 2025). *A lieu de mémoire* is meant to be the most durable form a memory can take. What 2024–2025 demonstrated is that in the connective condition even the most durable sites have become revisable at the speed of the feed — a memory could be canonised in stone for fifty years and unmade in an afternoon, the unmaking itself livestreamed and, in turn, minted onto the currency. The monopoly the state had defended with a memory law six years earlier did not merely erode. It was, in the space of months, overthrown, and its most solid monuments converted into contested content.

The stakes: what algorithmic custodianship does to national memory

If the custodianship of 1971 has passed, in the manner described, from the monument to the feed, four consequences follow for the character of the nation's memory, and they are worth naming without either technological panic or technological celebration.

The first is *deconsecration*. The monument surrounds a memory with a frame of reverence that instructs the visitor how to feel; the feed strips that frame away, placing the martyr and the *birangona* in the same scrolling plane as advertisement, entertainment, and outrage, and subjecting them to the same demand to perform. A memory that must compete for attention on engagement's terms cannot easily retain the solemnity that commemorative logic conferred on it. The second is *acceleration and volatility*. Nora (1989) already saw modern memory as living

under an "acceleration of history"; the feed sets that acceleration to a new order of magnitude. Where the meaning of a *lieu de mémoire* shifted over decades, the meaning of a memory-symbol on the platform can now overturn in days, as the fate of the word *razakar* in July 2024 showed. The third is the *inversion of mnemonic authority*. In the communicative regime the witness held the highest authority, because they had been there; in the connective regime the algorithm privileges present engagement over past testimony, so that the postmemory generation, which remembers nothing first-hand, sets the terms on which the war is now argued, precisely because its members are the platform's most active users. The fourth is *the arrival of denial and disinformation at scale*. The same infrastructure that let Shahbag reactivate the memory of 1971 lets historical revisionism — over the number of martyrs, over the scale of the rape, over the very character of the war — circulate with the frictionless reach that false and emotionally charged claims enjoy on engagement-optimised systems (Gillespie, 2014; Bucher, 2018). Custodianship by a system indifferent to truth is custodianship that serves the denialist and the commemorator with the same efficiency.

The three-million question: doubt as an engagement premium

Nothing illustrates the character of algorithmic custodianship more sharply than the fate, on the platform, of the war's central number. The canonical figure of three million martyrs has been contested since the war's immediate aftermath, and the scholarly argument over casualty counts is legitimate historical work (Bose, 2011). But the feed does not host that argument as historians host it. It hosts doubt as content, and doubt about a sacred number is unusually good content: it is emotionally charged, it is transgressive, it provokes furious reply, and provocation is what engagement-optimised systems elevate. Research on the diffusion of online information has shown that false and novel claims travel faster, farther, and deeper than true ones, precisely because they provoke the stronger reaction (Vosoughi, Roy, & Aral, 2018), and revisionism about 1971 enjoys exactly that structural premium. The result is not that denial wins outright, but that the number is placed in a condition of perpetual re-litigation, dragged back into dispute each time the algorithm finds that disputing it performs. What the monument settled by inscription — the figure carved once, beyond argument — the feed unsettles continuously, because on the feed the settled generates less engagement than the contested. This is the mechanism that Claire Wardle and Hossein Derakhshan (2017) call information disorder, applied to the founding

memory of a nation: not one decisive falsehood, but an ambient, profitable, self-renewing doubt that the infrastructure has every incentive to keep alive. A custodian that profits from controversy cannot be relied on to protect a consensus, and a national memory is, among other things, a consensus.

A counter-reading, and conclusion

Intellectual honesty requires the opposing case, because it is strong. The state's mnemonic monopoly was never benign. It was partial, party-bound, and enforced at the end by a memory law that jailed people for their representations of the past; and it purchased the solemnity this essay has described partly through silence — over the memories Saikia (2011) and Mookherjee (2015) recovered, over the complications of collaboration and of the war's non-Bengali victims, over everything the triumphal narrative could not hold. The connective condition, for all its volatility, broke that monopoly. It let suppressed and marginal memories surface, let a networked public demand a justice the state had deferred for forty years, and let a generation contest an official story it had inherited rather than chosen. If the feed deconsecrates, it also democratises; if it accelerates distortion, it also accelerates the recovery of what was buried. A memory governed by the monument alone is stable, but its stability is also its capacity to exclude.

The honest conclusion is therefore not that the feed has ruined the memory of 1971, nor that it has liberated it, but that it has changed the *kind* of thing that memory now is — and changed it at the most consequential possible moment. Bangladesh is completing the passage of its founding war from living memory into cultural memory, the passage every nation makes once and cannot repeat, and it is making that passage for the first time in history through an infrastructure it does not own and cannot fully govern, whose ranking logic answers to engagement rather than to either truth or dignity. The cultural memory of 1971 that emerges from this crossing will be built not in stone but in code, and code remembers differently than stone does: it reranks, it inflames, it forgets on a schedule set elsewhere, and it renders even the most solid monument revisable in an afternoon. The old question of Bangladeshi public life was which party would control the memory of the founding. The question the platform poses is stranger and larger — whether a nation can be said to hold its own founding memory at all, when the custodian of that memory has become a system optimised for attention and headquartered, in the end, somewhere far from Dhaka.

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